THE LAWS OF SOFTWARE TEAMS

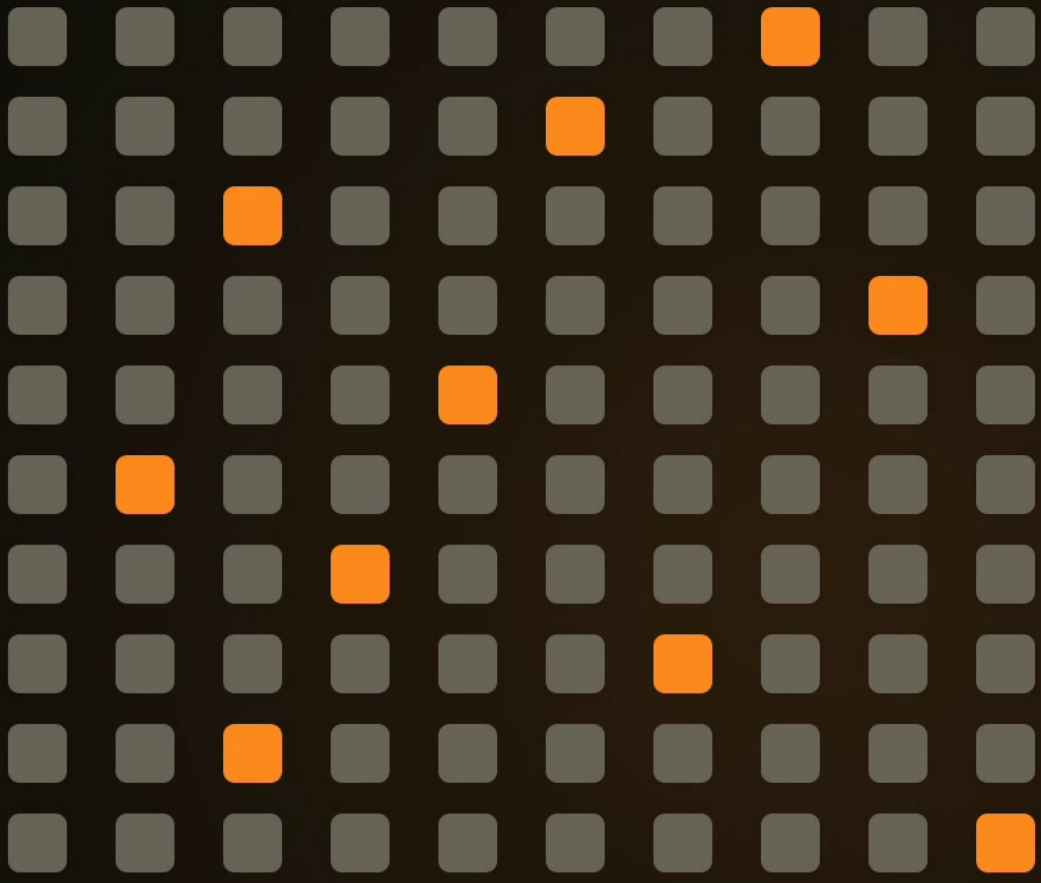
# Sturgeon's law

## Ninety percent of everything is crud

swipe →

Ivan Rykov

# 90% of everything is crud



books · movies · cars · your features

Ivan Rykov

# A sci-fi writer fights back

Theodore Sturgeon, science fiction author

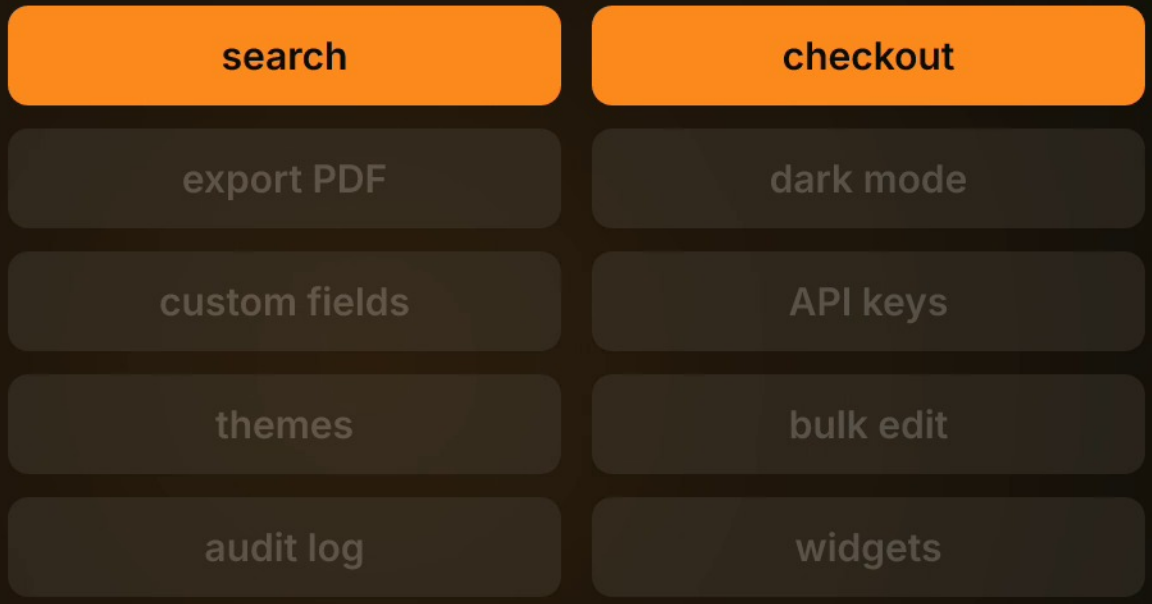
CRITICS
“90% of sci-fi is crud”

THEODORE STURGEON · 1957
“Sure. 90% of everything is crud”

## Sci-fi isn’t worse. Everything is mostly bad

Venture Science Fiction column, 1957 · wording paraphrased

# Most features go unused

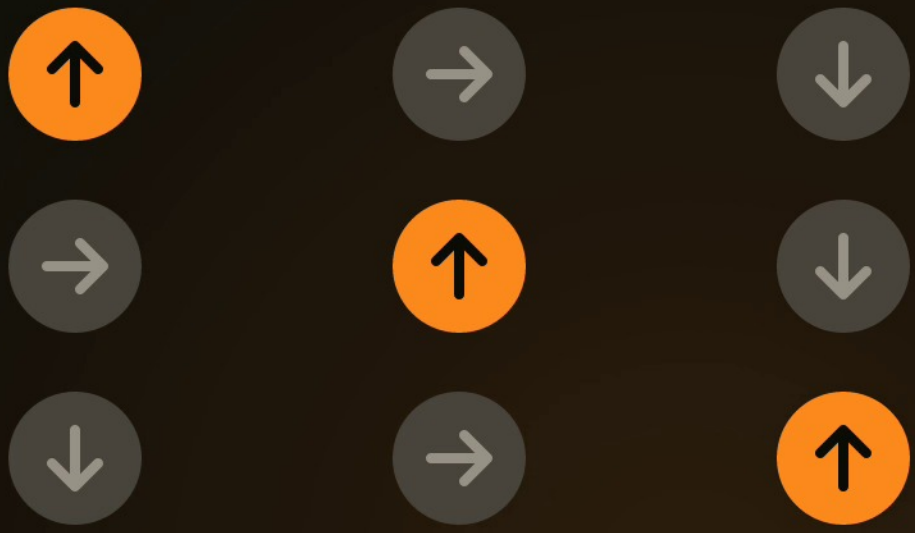



**80%** rarely or never used

Pendo Feature Adoption Report, 2019 · 615 customer subscriptions
feature names illustrative

# Even tested ideas mostly miss

Microsoft A/B experiments

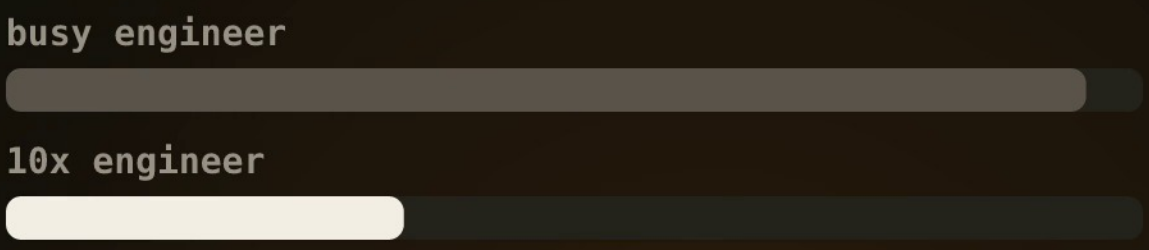


**~1 in 3** improved its metric

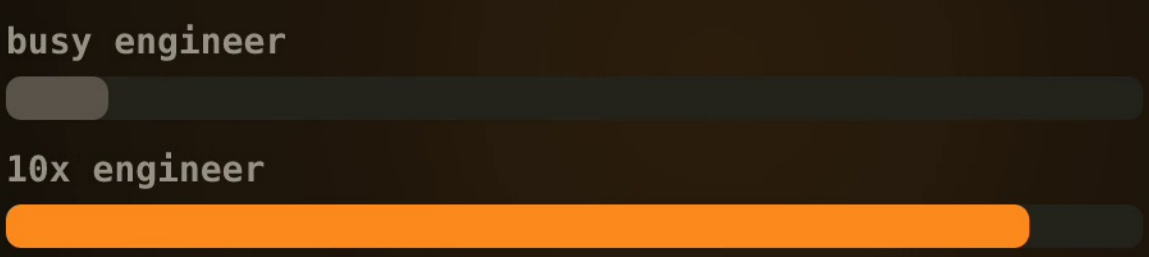
Kohavi et al., “Online Experimentation at Microsoft”, 2009 · rest: flat or worse

# 10x engineers don't write 10x code

## Code written




## Value created




**They pick the 10% that matters**

illustration · idea via manager.dev

06 WHAT TO DO

# Push back on the roadmap

Ideas on the roadmap



Ship small versions



Keep what people use



Cut what nobody touches

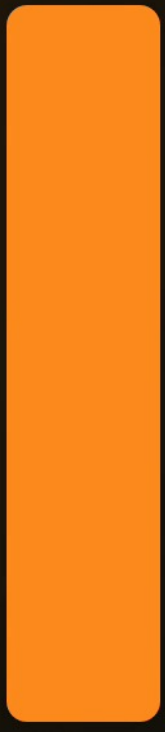
illustration

Ivan Rykov

# The crud doesn't go away

You maintain 100% of it, forever

- widgets
- audit log
- bulk edit
- themes
- API keys
- custom fields
- dark mode
- export PDF
- checkout
- search



maintenance

08 TAKEAWAY

# Find the 10%
# Say no to the rest



TAKEAWAY

# Find the 10%
# Say no to the rest

Sources: Theodore Sturgeon, 1957 · Pendo, 2019 · Kohavi, Crook and Longbotham, 2009

next: the law of triviality